The Musicians of Bremen

By Wilhelm and Jakob Grimm

Note: The humor of this selection comes through the characterization of each animal and robber as well as the reaction of the narrator to what is occurring. The more outrageous the better. Plan pantomimes, sounds and characters carefully.

INTRODUCTION

This story by the Brothers Grimm is about four farm animals who are convinced they can earn a good living as musicians. Indeed they do, but it isn't really the sweetness of their barking, braying, mewing, and cockle-doodle-doing, that earns them their supper – it's more the terror of the sound they make! The Musicians of Bremen by Wilhelm and Jakob Grimm

NARRATOR: A certain man had a Donkey that had served him faithfully for many long years, but whose strength was so far gone that at last he was quite unfit for work. So his master began to consider how much he could get for the Donkey's skin, but the beast, perceiving that something was up, ran away along the road to Bremen.

DONKEY: There I can be town musician.

NARRATOR: When he had run some way, he found a Hound lying by the roadside, yawning like one who was very tired.

DONKEY: What are you doing that, you big fellow?

HOUND: Ah, because every day I grow older and weaker. I can no longer run with the hunt, and my master has almost beaten me to death. So I took flight, and now I do not know where to turn in order to earn my bread.

DONKEY: Well, I am going to Bremen, to be town musician there. Suppose you go with me and take a share in the music. I will play the lute, and you shall beat the kettledrums.

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NARRATOR: The Hound was pleased with the plan, and off they set. Presently they came to a Cat, sitting in the middle of the path, with a face like three rainy days!

DONKEY: Now, then, Old Whiskers, what is bothering you?

CAT: How can one be merry when one's neck is in danger? Because I am growing old, and my teeth are all worn to stumps, and because I would rather sit by the fire than run after mice, my mistress wanted to drown me; and so I ran away. But good advice is hard to find, and now I do not know what to do.

DONKEY: Come with us to Bremen. You are an expert at night music, so you can be town musician, too.

NARRATOR: The Cat agreed, and went along with them. The three vagabonds soon came to a farmyard, where a Cock was sitting on a barn door crowing with all his might.

DONKEY: Your crowing can pierce through marrow and bone. What do you do that for?

COCK: That is the way I prophesy fine weather. But important guests are coming for Sunday dinner tomorrow, and my mistress has told the cook to make me into soup. Tonight I shall lose my head, so I am crowing with a full throat as long as I can.

DONKEY: Ah, but you, Red-comb, should come away with us. We are going to Bremen, to find something better than death. You have a good voice, and if we four make music together it will have full play.

NARRATOR: The Cock was delighted with the idea, and so all four traveled on together. They could not, however, reach Bremen in one day, and at evening they came into a forest, where they meant to pass the night. The Donkey and the Hound lay down under a large tree. The Cat and the Cock climbed up into the branches, but the latter flew right to the top, where he was most safe.

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Before he went to sleep he looked around the countryside and thought he saw a little spark in the distance.

COCK: [We] are not far from a house, for [I] saw a light.

DONKEY: If it is so, we had better get up and go toward it, for it's not very comfortable here in this place.

HOUND: Yes, indeed! A couple of bones with meat on them would be very acceptable!

NARRATOR: So they made haste toward the spot where the light was, and which shone brighter and brighter, until they came to a well-lighted robber's den. The Donkey, as the biggest, went to the window and peeped in.

COCK: What do you see, Gray Horse?

DONKEY: What do I see? I see a table laid out with savory meats and drinks, and robbers sitting around enjoying themselves.

COCK: That would be the right sort of thing for us.

DONKEY: Yes, yes, I wish we were sitting there.

NARRATOR: Then these animals took counsel together how to drive away the robbers, and at last they thought of a plan. The Donkey placed his forefeet upon the window ledge, the Hound got on his back, the Cat climbed up upon the Hound, and, lastly, the Cock flew up and perched upon the Cat. When this was accomplished, at a given signal they commenced together to perform their music. The Donkey brayed, the Hound barked, the Cat meowed, and the Cock crowed; and they made such a tremendous noise that the windowpanes splintered and crashed. Terrified at these unearthly sounds, the robbers jumped up, thinking that some demons had burst in on them, and fled off into the forest. The four musicians immediately made themselves at home, and quickly ate all that was left, as if they had been fasting for six weeks. As soon as they had finished, they put out the light, and each sought for himself a sleeping-place, according to his nature and

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custom. The Donkey stretched out upon some straw, the Hound behind the door, the Cat upon the hearth near the warm ashes, and the Cock flew up on a beam which ran across the room. Weary with their long walk, they soon went to sleep. At midnight the robbers could see from their retreat that no light was burning in their house, and everything appeared quiet.

CAPTAIN: We need not have been frightened into fits.

NARRATOR: And, calling one of the band, he sent him forward to reconnoiter. The messenger, finding all still, went into the kitchen to strike a light, and, taking the glistening, fiery eyes of the cat for live coals, he held a match to them, expecting the match to take fire. But the Cat flew in his face, spitting and scratching, and frightening him so dreadfully that he made for the back door; then the Hound, who lay nearby, sprang up and bit his leg; and as he limped over the straw where the Donkey was stretched out, it gave him a powerful kick with its hind foot. This was not all, for the Cock, awaked by the noise around him, and cried from his perch on the beam:

COCK: Cock-a-doodle-doo, cock-a-doodle-do!

NARRATOR: Then the robber ran back as fast as he could to his captain and cried,

ROBBER: Ah, my master, there dwells a horrible witch in the house, who spat on me and scratched my face with her long nails. In front of the door stands a man with a knife, who chopped at my leg; and in the yard there lies a black monster, who beat me with a great wooden club. In addition to all that, upon the roof sits a judge, who called out, 'Bring the knave up, do!' -- so I ran away as fast as I could.

NARRATOR: After this the robbers dared not go near their house again, but everything prospered so well with the four town musicians of Bremen, that they never left their new home. And there they have been from that day to this, for all I know.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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